

Severity vs Priority Guide

Stop confusing "how bad" with "how soon" — and log defects that get actioned.

Introduction

Severity and priority are two of the most misunderstood attributes on a defect report. They are independent: a defect can be highly severe but low priority, or trivial but urgent. Getting them right means the team fixes the right things at the right time. This guide defines both, shows the four combinations and gives a worked matrix.

Definitions

Attribute	Answers the question	Usually set by
Severity	How badly does this defect affect the system or user?	The tester (technical impact)
Priority	How soon should this defect be fixed?	Product owner / business (business urgency)

Why They Are Independent

Severity is about technical impact and is relatively objective. Priority is about business urgency and depends on context — release dates, how many users hit the issue, contractual obligations. Because they answer different questions, all four combinations of high/low are possible and legitimate.

The Four Combinations — worked matrix

Combination	Example	Typical action
High severity, High priority	Payment processing crashes for all users on checkout	Fix immediately — blocks release
High severity, Low priority	App crashes on an obsolete browser used by 0.1% of users	Serious, but can wait — schedule for later
Low severity, High priority	Company logo is misspelt on the home page	Cosmetic, but embarrassing — fix before launch
Low severity, Low priority	Minor typo in a rarely visited help page	Fix when convenient / backlog

The high-severity/low-priority and low-severity/high-priority rows are the ones that prove the two attributes are not the same thing. Expect at least one exam question probing this.

Example Severity Scale

Severity level	Meaning
Critical / Blocker	System crash, data loss, or complete feature unusable with no workaround
Major	Significant feature broken but a workaround exists
Minor	Small functional issue with little impact
Cosmetic / Trivial	UI/spelling issue not affecting function

What Else a Good Defect Report Contains

- Unique ID and clear, specific title
- Steps to reproduce, expected result and actual result
- Environment (build, browser, OS, device)
- Severity and priority
- Evidence — screenshots, logs, video
- Status and, where known, the root cause or affected area

Exam Traps & Common Mistakes

- Treating severity and priority as the same thing — the classic error.
- Assuming high severity always means high priority (the obsolete-browser crash disproves this).
- Letting testers set priority — priority is a business decision, severity is the tester's call.
- Vague titles ("it doesn't work") that give triage nothing to act on.

WATCH OUT

A defect being severe does not entitle it to be fixed first. Priority is decided by the business against release goals. Log the severity accurately, then let priority be set separately — never conflate the two.

Best Practices

- Set severity from technical impact; leave priority to the product owner.
- Write titles a triager can action without opening the report.
- Always attach evidence and reproduction steps to justify the severity you assign.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

When you log a defect, ask two separate questions: "How badly does this break things?" (severity) and "How soon does the business need it fixed?" (priority). Answer them independently and your reports will be triaged far faster.